moved to New Delhi in the role of party chief, as the plan then was. Gehlot had offered to quit in favour of any suitable candidate—except bete noire Sachin Pilot—who could assure victory in the assembly polls due in December 2023. But his camp had sensed the wind. The 92 MLAs, all Gehlot loyalists, holed up at urban development and housing minister Shanti Kumar Dhariwal's residence instead of turning up for the meet, and submitted their resignations to the assembly speaker. Gehlot won that round, preferring to retain Jaipur over having a go at AICC presidency.

The three leaders against whom Maken wanted action—Dhariwal, public health engineering minister Mahesh Joshi, and Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation chairperson Dharmendra Rathore—had earlier been served a showcause notice by the party to explain their open defiance on September 25. All three are extremely close to Gehlot. The acceptance of Maken's resignation now seals Gehlot's victory; the party is evidently in no mood to cross the CM at this stage.

THE GEHLOT-PILOT SAGA POSES UNIQUE DILEMMAS: KHARGE HAS SEALED THE CM'S VICTORY WITH HIS SILENCE, THE GANDHIS SEEM AMBIVALENT IN DIFFERENT WAYS

"Maken, despite his proximity to the Gandhi family, proved to be a disaster in handling crises in Punjab and now Rajasthan, besides failing to win a safe Rajya Sabha seat in Haryana. We need mature leader as in-charge and hope Randhawa does his homework well, instead of working on some agenda," says a party veteran. Congress leader Jairam Ramesh also weighed in on Maken's resignation. "Sometimes some may feel that their resignation may not be accepted, but his has been," he said.

All these allusions to Punjab, including by Randhawa, are not without a portentous weight. In September 2021, the Congress had replaced Capt Amarinder Singh with Charanjit Singh Channi as CM. This was preceded by months of fractiousness in the state unit, a situation that persists. In the 2022 assembly polls, the party tanked, winning only 18 seats. Some Rajasthan party MLAs who met Kharge say the new in-charge is determined to not let Rajasthan go the Punjab way.

There are others, though, who feel that may be optimistic. Though the Bharat Jodo Yatra entered Rajasthan on December 4 and is visibly enthusing Congress workers, what Randhawa can do to bring about a truce between Gehlot and Pilot is anybody's guess. Some in the party are in fact worried about Randhawa fuelling further tension between the two. Not surprising, since Randhawa himself was a prime participant in the Congress's Punjab slugfest—a bitter and vocal rival of Amarinder, it was believed that Maken and Rajasthan MLA Harish Chaudhary, the two Congress observers for Punjab, had suggested his name as CM, before the high command chose Channi. Randhawa, however, says "his name was indeed mooted for CM, but as a disciplined Congressman, he accepted it when he was made deputy CM". Perhaps a message to Pilot to accept whatever assignment he is offered.

Randhawa's main task in Rajasthan—to pacify the warring Gehlot and Pilot factions—is challenging. While on a visit to Jaipur to oversee preparations for the Bharat Jodo Yatra, AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal had on November 29 tried to broker a truce between the two at a closed-door meeting after another bout of public recriminations. Pilot had begun that round by accusing Gehlot of following in the footsteps of former Congress veteran Ghulam Nabi Azad, who quit the party in August, allegedly at the behest of "his political bosses". Thereafter, a few leaders, including ministers, jumped into the fray, speaking out both for and against the CM. Finally, in an interview to NDTV, Gehlot said Pilot could never be made CM as party MLAs would not accept a 'traitor' who had tried to bring down the government. "If Pilot feels humiliated, he must learn to bear it as I do," Gehlot told INDIA TODAY recently.

At a meeting in Jaipur during his visit, Venugopal's strict warning to Rajasthan Congress leaders against indiscipline and speaking about the party to the media was openly challenged by Harish Chaudhary, who said "one would speak one's mind". Venugopal reminded him that as a senior leader, a CWC member and in-charge of Punjab he had to follow party diktat. As Gehlot and Pilot smiled together for a photoshoot, Chaudhary defiantly tweeted a Che Guevara quote: "I have also seen in the cemetery graves of those who did not fight so that they might not be killed." Chaudhary was dropped as revenue minister when he was made in-charge of Punjab. He has been challenging Gehlot of late.

It is not clear what has actuated Chaudhary—a bid to regain his place in the state cabinet or a nudge from someone in the Gandhi family. "There is a growing feeling that Priyanka Gandhi is anti-Gehlot," says a state unit vice-president. Some even speculate whether Priyanka is targeting Gehlot using the same leaders she had used against Amarinder. Many of the MLAs and ministers who had boycotted the September 25 meeting accuse Maken of planning it, and of telling Kharge—who too had come as observer—that Pilot was a popular choice for CM.

On the other hand, Sonia Gandhi is seen by some as "soft" on Gehlot . "As interim president then, she had agreed to his request not to contest the AICC election and stay on as CM," says the